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Narrating the Process: Questioning the Progressive Story of European Integration*

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Abstract

Underlying scholarship on the EU is the conviction that the institutions of the EU are the outcome of a historical process whereby national institutions are being superseded and replaced by supranational ones. The article criticizes this tendency, for two reasons. First, it argues that the progressive conception has led to the story of the EU being told in over-simplified and unhistorical ways. Second, it suggests that the progressive conception has blinded authors to the possibility that alternative narratives of European integration are possible and that these may come to predominate if the European project loses its aura of success.

Introduction

Almost all scholars of European integration – historians and political scientists alike – have been concerned to characterize 'the process' as a gradual erosion of national sovereignty and the evolution of new, post-national

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institutions at European level. Alan S. Milward disagreed, but his work stands out like a sore thumb precisely for this reason. There is, of course, much disagreement about what the causes of the process are and have been, but there is almost no dispute that this historical shift has taken place and that it is, moreover, a profoundly desirable development. The concluding lines of Pierre Gerbet's majestic *La Construction de l'Europe*, which, intentionally echoing Jean Monnet, calls the process of European integration '*l'enterprise sans doute la plus originale et la plus féconde de notre siècle*' is a conclusion with which few regular writers on European integration would disagree (Gerbet, 1999, p. 561).

Scholarship on European integration has its foundations, therefore, in a progressive rather than protean interpretation of Europe's contemporary history. The very word 'process', which is, after all, a metaphor of sorts, conveys a notion of inevitability, or, at any rate, of predictability. There is an air of almost Victorian certainty about much European integration scholarship. All the main narrative accounts that are examined in this article – despite their various virtues – share a belief that integration represents a trend from which there will be no receding.

This belief may be true; certainly, this article is *not* suggesting the contrary. This article does intend, however, to do two possibly unsettling things. First, in the spirit of Herbert Butterfield's remark that history 'is the study of the complexity that underlies any generalization that we want to make', it shows that existing progressive narratives of European integration are susceptible to revision (Butterfield, 1973, p. 57). They over-simplify, even caricature and distort, the historical record. This article further asks, however, what would happen to general narratives of European integration if the EU were to lose its aura of progressivism: if it were to be seen in a negative light; as a failure, or obstacle, rather than as a model to imitate. After all, one need not be a Eurosceptic to see that the possibility of such a shift in perceptions exists:

> The ongoing institutional unification of Europe may be seen as (and prove to be) a defensive move prompted by the impulse to defend Europe's 'is' (its relatively peaceful niche amidst deepening planetary turmoil, its privileged life standards amidst worldwide deprivation) against the 'ought' of its challenging, uncomfortable yet imperative planetary responsibilities. But it may also prove to be a preliminary step to gather resources, force and will, all necessary to tackle the tasks of supracontinental, planetary dimensions. (Bauman, 2004, p. 37)

Insofar as the EU *may* be cast in the future as a reactionary force – as a bankrupter of gauchos, rather than as a deliverer from war – Bauman is

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indicating a pathway for future historiography. Historians, to quote Lewis Namier, must 'single out and stress that which is the nature of the thing and not [. . .] reproduce indiscriminately all that meets the eye' (Namier, 1952 in Stern, 1970, p. 379). The sheer volume of known facts about the past – especially the recent past – requires historians to make a statement of what the object of study essentially *amounts to* and then use that judgement as a criterion for structuring their narratives. Should the perception grow that at bottom the EU is one way in which the rich world protects itself from the huddled masses elsewhere in the world, future historians will give pride of place in their narratives to working out how this state of affairs came to pass; to tracing the causal sequences that led to the construction of a heartless economic ogre, rather than celebrating through analysis the institutional bargains of the past six decades. The story that is depicted depends on what historians think the EU represents in wider historical terms. Thus far, European integration has – understandably – been associated with the elimination of war between Europe's nation-states and the generation of prosperity. This does not mean that it always will be.

I. The Orthodox Story

The European Commission has no doubts about what European integration represents and has tried its hardest to diffuse an orthodox narrative of how the Union was constructed, as even a brief glance at the *Europa* website shows. Moreover, as is well-known, the eminent French historian Jean-Baptiste Duroselle was commissioned to write a broad history of European civilization and to deal with the significance of European integration for that history. His book (Duroselle, 1990) was then translated into several European languages and published all over Europe, with the then EC's open patronage (the English translator was Richard Mayne, who was a private secretary to Jean Monnet and a historian of the EEC before becoming editor of the prestigious literary and political review, *Encounter*). Duroselle's pithy account, at the end of his book, of the foundation of the EEC and the early development of European integration is a masterpiece of didactic history and may be said to epitomize one progressive conception of the history of European integration.

Duroselle begins by describing the situation in Europe at the dawn of the cold war. It was, he says, a 'discouraging moment for the construction of Europe'. However, the hour brought forth 'the intervention of men of great stature, principal among them Jean Monnet'. In 1949–50, Duroselle states, Monnet was 'grappling' with various grave problems: the question of the Saar, the coal shortage, the slowness of the construction of Europe as a result

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of the 'semi-paralysis' of the Council of Europe – you have to imagine a weary titan, working alone while Acheson, Bevin, Marjolin and Adenauer slept. Together with a handful of collaborators, Monnet drew up an 'extraordinary plan' that did not convince prime minister Georges Bidault, but which did 'seduce' Robert Schuman. The French foreign minister's role was therefore less laudable than Monnet's, but his 'energy' enabled the plan to overcome 'formidable resistance' from the Communists and from the French ironmakers' federation.

The eventual ECSC treaty, according to Duroselle, was an 'enormous achievement' which had the good fortune to be sustained by 'other convinced Europeans' such as Adenauer and De Gasperi. Not even the 'setback' of the 'premature' attempt to construct a defence community could thwart European construction. Once again, Monnet (who, Duroselle editorializes, 'well deserves the epithet of "father of Europe"') intervened to create the Action Committee. Its discussions gave new impetus to the Messina process and led directly, despite prolonged negotiations, to the treaties of Rome. Things were going well again, but in 1958, as a result of the Algerian crisis, an 'ardent paladin of the nation' became President in France. De Gaulle's vision of Europe's role, with its proud assertion of national sovereignty and its rooted anti-Americanism, was too radical for the Six. It was not until De Gaulle was diminished by the events of 1968–69 that French foreign policy ambitions became more 'modest' and once again 'favoured further steps forward in the construction of Europe' (Duroselle, 1990, pp. 395–403).

So recounted, the partisanship of the book is evident, which may be why in the conclusion Duroselle went out of his way defensively to assert that he and his collaborators had done their best merely to write 'nothing other than the truth' (Duroselle, 1990, p. 411). At the same time, he admitted that his 'enterprise' did have a 'political connotation' that he no longer wished to 'hide'. This political connotation was his 'propensity' for a 'Europe that is slowly heading towards political unity'. The whole objective of the volume, of recounting the history of Europe from prehistoric times to the fall of the Berlin wall, was to explore whether there were the 'premises for a united Europe'. He concludes that there are. Since 'Europe has always existed, independently of its nations, our ideal of a united Europe seems to us to be not so much "justified" [. . .] as "validated" by history' (Duroselle, 1990, p. 411).[1] It is hard not to share Garton Ash's diagnosis that Duroselle's story is a 'mythopoeic falsification of our history' (Garton Ash, 2007, p. 1).

Duroselle's narrative, or something akin to it, is nevertheless standard fare in textbooks of EU studies and in much public discourse. There is no space

[1] The citations are my translations from Duroselle 1990, not Mayne's translation from the French original.

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here to do a full historiographical analysis, but I think most readers will acknowledge that much writing on the history of European integration is characterized by certain common rhetorical devices that were evident in the passages from Duroselle quoted above:

a) *choice of terms*: construction metaphors abound. References to Europe's 'path', 'march', 'advance', 'progress' are also commonplace. Moments of relative inactivity are described as 'stagnation' – the 1970s, for instance, are frequently referred to in this way. The process is nevertheless always 're-launched' or 'revived' after moments of difficulty. In general, narratives *personify* the process, turning it into a creature with a vital life of its own that enables it to overcome 'set-backs' – to mention another commonly employed word.
b) *authorial judgements*: the standard used to measure whether major decisions were successes or failures is almost always whether they augmented or reduced the overall degree of supranationality within the Community. Dozens of examples might be given, but one will have to suffice here. Here is the Italian author Bino Olivi's judgement on the Single European Act (SEA):

> The intergovernmental conference's attempt to arrive at a treaty instituting European Union had failed; the contents of the SEA were inadequate and piecemeal (*inorganico*), less comprehensive than even the most pessimistic predictions on the eve of the talks (Olivi, 2000, p. 301, author's own translation).

Here, the SEA is represented as an abysmal flop solely because the IGC did not transform the draft constitution proposed by the European Parliament in February 1984 into treaty form (a prospect that was never on the agenda, in any case). This is an extreme example, but it is a general rule that orthodox historiography uses approving language to describe increases in supranationalism but employs words like 'limited', 'minor', 'tinkering', 'piecemeal' and so on whenever relatively few gains were made for the principle of supranationality.

c) *Monnet and his mates*: orthodox narratives are in many ways the last bastion of 'great man' history. To a quite remarkable extent given current practice in historiography, the process is regarded as being advanced or retarded at every single juncture by 'eminent Europeans' (Bond *et al.*, 1996). To quote Gerbet again, referring to the Messina process: '*Cette relance européenne a été le fait de petits groupes d'hommes, qui voulaient continuer à construire l'Europe, en particulier de Jean Monnet et de ses amis et des dirigeants du Benelux qui*

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prirent les initiatives nécessaries' (Gerbet, 1999, p. 163). In some Italian historiography, Altiero Spinelli is regarded as a figure whose actions and writings are of defining importance for the Age, let alone the European Community, while the volume of writings on the 'founding fathers' is both immense and often semi-hagiographic (Pistone, 1999; Anta, 2007).

II. Whigs. . . .

In critiquing orthodox narratives, an obligatory comment is that, making due allowance for perspective, the story that they tell is astonishingly similar to the narrative put forward by the anti-EU fringe. Eurosceptics believe that the EU is an élite conspiracy against Europe's peoples that is one of the 'great collective acts of make-believe of the twentieth century' (Booker and North, 2003, p. 454); orthodox historians believe that 'Europe' has been constructed by an enlightened political class to save the continent from relapsing into war and barbarism. Beneath the surface rhetoric, the diagnosis is surprisingly similar.

A second comment is drawn from the research presented by Alan Milward in the *Reconstruction of Western Europe 1945–51* and Milward and his collaborators in *The European Rescue of the Nation State*. Whether or not one agrees with Milward's broader thesis that the construction of European institutions in the 1950s was 'an integral part of the reassertion of the nation-state as an organizational concept' (Milward, 2000, p. 7), his work has clearly shown, for example, that it is exaggerated to regard the Schuman Plan as being solely a piece of brilliant improvisation by Monnet, has rightly emphasized how the trade liberalization achieved by the European Payments Union and the OEEC created the momentum that made the EEC a possibility, has underlined the extent to which anticommunism was at work in the minds of the men he calls, tongue firmly in cheek, the 'European Saints'. One could and should add that both Milward and Hans-Peter Schwarz have underlined the extent to which Monnet and Schuman were motivated in 1950 by straightforward concerns of French national interest (see Schwarz, 1995, p. 510). None of this is to say that Monnet was unimportant: it is merely a reminder that he was operating in a context of the broader *context* of postwar reconstruction. It is as facile to identify the construction of European institutions with the initiatives of Monnet and his collaborators as it is to say that Stalin (or Truman) was responsible for the cold war.

Third, and most important, the orthodox story is Whig history in its purest form – a point that has been made by Timothy Garton Ash in various lectures

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and articles, and by me in *Surpassing Realism: The Politics of European Integration since 1945*, but which might usefully be underlined, because once one looks at the history of European integration from this perspective, its contours immediately take on a different shape and some of its landmarks look less well-defined (Garton Ash, 1996; Gilbert, 2003).

'Whig history' is a term invented by the British scholar Herbert Butterfield in 1931 to characterize a habit of mind that he regarded as extremely common among the historians of his day. To quote Butterfield's biographer C.T. McIntire, it is 'the fallacy of reading the past wholly in the light of the present [. . .] the meta-narrative that told of history as progress towards something approved in the present or in the hoped-for future' (McIntire, 2004, p. ix). This habit of mind is very evident in the orthodox historiography of European integration. It is for this reason that one often reads of de Gaulle (or Thatcher, or economic crisis in the 1970s, or recalcitrant voters in Denmark) 'blocking' or 'obstructing' the process until the action of human agents imbued with the correct dose of Community spirit relaunch the process on its way. Butterfield, by contrast, urges scholars to remember that 'history is not the study of origins; rather, it is the analysis of all the mediations by which the past was turned into our present' (Butterfield, 1973, p. 40). Again: 'Instead of seeing the modern world emerge as the victory of the children of light over the children of darkness in any generation, it is at least better to see it emerge as the result of a clash of wills, a result which neither party wanted or even dreamed of, a result which indeed in some cases both parties would equally have hated, but a result for the achievement of which the existence of both and the clash of both were necessary' (Butterfield, 1973, p. 28).[2]

The value of adopting Butterfield's approach when we narrate European integration is that it enables us to see facts that the orthodox narrative shrinks from recognizing. For example, that the European Union, as it exists today, owes as much, perhaps more, to the actions of Charles de Gaulle and Margaret Thatcher as it does to the actions of, say, Jean Monnet and Jacques Delors.

What was de Gaulle's contribution? He insisted upon a formal role for the heads of government in the Community's decision-making and showed he was prepared to block the work of the Community unless the Member States could preserve a right of veto, thus ensuring that the EC remained an intergovernmental organization. The European Council, whose central role in the development of the EC since the mid-1970s cannot be disputed, is fundamentally a Gaullist concept. The creation of a strategic decision-making body

[2] Compare Butterfield with Alan Milward's comments about the 'founding fathers' of the EEC in Milward (2000, p. 318).

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composed of the heads of government presented obvious problems for advocates of strong supranational institutions.

Even if this is regarded as going too far, and it may be, recent empirical studies have underlined that de Gaulle's policy towards the EEC in the 1960s was far from being merely destructive. According to an outstanding recent book by N. Piers Ludlow, the idea that the 'empty chair' crisis was a '*vital caesura*' between the 'vibrant and active Community of the early 1960s' and the 'stagnant, fractious entity' of the 1970s and 1980s, is, to use his word, 'simplistic' (Ludlow, 2006, p. 118). De Gaulle's actions, Ludlow believes, served the useful purpose of compelling the Member States 'to assess what sort of European system they wanted and to reject more clearly than before what they did not wish to see' (Ludlow, 2006, p. 119). De Gaulle, in effect, made the EEC grow up.

The same is just as true of Margaret Thatcher. What was her vital contribution to the history of European integration? Her contribution was almost to wreck the Community by her insistence on Britain's rebate and then to show remarkable and unexpected flexibility in surrendering the British veto for single market questions during the SEA IGC in the autumn of 1985. This facilitated the EC's turn towards the greater economic liberalization which has been a central feature of European integration ever since. This is not to say that Thatcher imposed economic liberalization on the Community. It was high on everybody's agenda. But Thatcher's willingness to block the Community in other areas, and her openness (indeed enthusiasm) in this area, made it a path the Community could take.

De Gaulle and Thatcher's ability to impose their will on the rest of the Community are, in short, not anomalies in the history of European integration, but *turning points for it*. Too often, scholars of European integration treat the 1960s and the early 1980s (or, indeed, the whole period 1963–84) as parentheses in the history of European integration. Like Benedetto Croce, who, during Fascism, wrote a history of Italy from 1870 to 1915 that ended with the author's belief that what had happened since 1915 had had *niente a che fare* with the real trend of Italian history, which was the consolidation of liberty in parliamentary institutions, so much of the historiography of the EU pretends that Charles de Gaulle was an aberration rather than an integral part of the story (Croce, 1929).

III. . . . And Wonks

Political scientists have shied away from historical interpretations in recent years. But in the past, political science, as a by-product of its attempt to

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'theorize the process' coincidentally generated two important narrative accounts of European integration, which have greatly contributed, especially in the US, to consolidating the progressive perception of European integration. Borrowing from Craig Parsons (Parsons, 2002), this article refers to these as the 'institutionalist' and 'structuralist' narratives.

The 'institutionalist' narrative emerged from theoretical attempts to explain the rise of European institutions and the emergence of a political community in western Europe in the immediate post-war period. The process known as 'spillover' in the ECSC led to the decision to create the EEC and this, Ernst Haas contended, would accelerate the process both by generating new demands for increased powers for the Community's institutions and by creating the community-mindedness necessary for a genuine political community to emerge. 'The spillover may make a political community of Europe before the end of the transition period', Haas remarked hopefully (Haas, 1968, p. 311). Now, as Haas himself admitted in the second edition of the *Uniting of Europe*, this portrayal was entirely deterministic: 'the phenomenon of de Gaulle is omitted, the superiority of step-by-step economic decisions over crucial political choices is assumed as permanent' (Haas, 1968, p. xxix). Such institutional determinism took no account of the Member States' individual 'historical situations', as Stanley Hoffmann pointed out at the time (Hoffmann, 1966).

'Institutionalism' revived (and took on varying and multiple forms) with the EC's decision to launch the 1992 project in 1986. In brief, the 'institutionalism' assumes that the integration process stagnated until it was revived in the mid-1980s by a combination of changing world economic conditions (the relative decline of the US, the economic challenge of Japan, the failure of traditional strategies for creating economic growth in the 1970s), the judicial activism of the European Court of Justice, which established the principle of the supremacy of Community law and the policy entrepreneurship of Jacques Delors and his Commission from 1985 onwards (Sandholtz and Zysman, 1989; Keohane and Hoffmann, 1991; Pierson, 1996).

A timely combination of human and structural forces, therefore, breathed fresh life into the process and set off a new phase of integration. The SEA and Mediterranean enlargement put the questions of regional aid, free movement of citizens and monetary union on the table, not to mention the social dimension of the single market. These changed conditions generated new initiatives by the Commission and by national leaders and led to the Treaties of Schengen and of Maastricht, which have themselves generated pressures for the 'Europeanization' of Member States, for co-operation in justice and home affairs and also for new forms of 'governance' to manage the supranational polity thus created.

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Institutionalism sees European integration, in other words, as a history of elite political bargaining generating both intended and unintended ripple effects but leading, ultimately, to ever more complex forms of supranational government (not a federal superstate) whose justification, ultimately, will be utilitarian and whose citizens, basking in blissful ignorance, will 'trust his/her representatives to do the best for them' (Wessels, 1997, p. 291). As Marks *et al.* argued in a well-known article, 'instead of being explicitly challenged, states in the EU are being melded gently into a multi-level polity by their leaders and the actions of numerous sub-national and supranational actors' (Marks *et al.*, 2006, p. 375).

There is a blithe confidence in the inevitability of this process that has bemused some scholars. Jim Buller has argued in a thoughtful account of how the Thatcher government chose to join the EMS that 'Europeanization may not always be something that "happens" to domestic agents. It can be the outcome of an intensely political process reflecting strategic conflict between actors with different interests and beliefs' (Buller, 2006, p. 405). But Buller is, if anything, underestimating the significance of his point. Politics is nearly always an intense process that involves a clash of conflicting perspectives. The fundamental shortcoming of the implicit narrative generated by institutionalist accounts is that it lacks all sense of the *drama* inherent in politics (because there cannot be drama unless you entertain the possibility of multiple outcomes). It lacks a sense of drama principally because, repeating the error made by Haas and others in the 1960s, 'institutionalists' all but write flesh-and-blood political leaders out of the story. A recent 510-page compilation of essays on the theory of European integration by eminent political scientists from both the US and Europe contains no reference to – and this is an abbreviated list – Konrad Adenauer, Willy Brandt, Joschka Fischer, Hans-Dietrich Genscher, Valèry Giscard D'Estaing, Alcide De Gasperi, Edward Heath, Helmut Kohl, François Mitterrand, Georges Pompidou, Helmut Schmidt, Paul-Henri Spaak and Margaret Thatcher, although its various contributors do dissert at length on the relative roles of governmental and non-governmental actors in the process (Eilstrup-Sangiovanni, 2006). For any historian, this is abstraction run mad.

It is also, incidentally, for this reason that 'institutionalist' accounts have had difficulties with the 1970s and early 1980s. It is not just that the European Council is invented in the 1970s; that the EC signs the Helsinki accords and plays a major role in the negotiations; that the European Parliament is directly elected; that enlargement to four new Member States was agreed and that the Court of Justice makes several of its most crucial innovations in supranational jurisprudence – although it is a little disconcerting to see such vital events routinely dismissed as stagnation when, lately, even federalist historians have

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begun to re-evaluate the decade much more positively (Elvert, 2006). The real point is that the 1970s and early 1980s are years of turmoil, not gradual gains, in which individual politicians took unplottable decisions that visibly changed the course of events, be they Nixon going off gold to win the 1972 presidential elections, Mitterrand promising and, more recklessly still, actually trying to build socialism in one country, Thatcher slapping her handbag on the table and demanding her money back in one European Council meeting after another. That in the meantime, hundreds of proposals to eliminate discrepancies in the single market piled up unheeded in the Commission's archives, is testimony not to the process's stagnation, but simply to the power of history to interfere with public administration.

The 'structuralist' explanation of the construction of the EU proposed by Andrew Moravcsik also generates a narrative of its own, this time with characters. In Moravcsik's case, however, the problem is that the characters are one-dimensional. Writing in the context of the intense academic debate in international relations theory between the dominant neo-realist school and their neo-liberal rivals, Moravcsik sees the EU as being a development of huge theoretical (and not only historical) importance. As he says at the end of *The Choice for Europe*, European Union is in fact 'a global harbinger' of future attempts to establish supranational political structures elsewhere in the world (Moravcsik, 1998, p. 500). The quintessentially academic neorealist/neoliberal debate, in fact, was quickened in the 1990s by the Maastricht treaty and the sight of 12 west European nations making a broadly concerted effort to pool national sovereignty in a large range of competences that had previously belonged exclusively to the nation state. After all, if one argues that structures resembling the EU are going to become, if not commonplace then at any rate more common, then state-centric theories of world politics like neorealism are superseded. They do not tell the truth about the nature of the world and hence are defective as a predictive guide (Collard-Wexler, 2006).

The whole of Moravcsik's work on the EU seems to me to be permeated by his desire to prove this theoretical point. He is pursuing a valuable inquiry. It is just a pity that his explanation for the development of the EU – broadly speaking that the Member States of the European Community have pressed for European integration at various moments at the behest of economic producer groups and, secondarily, as a way of adjusting to upheavals in the world economy and have created the EU's institutions as a way of 'locking in' in the economic bargains made – should present so many difficulties for narrative purposes (Moravcsik, 1998, p. 3).

In Moravcsik's work, time passes, actors and circumstances change, new challenges arise, but the song of political behaviour remains the same. For Moravcsik's account to be true, one has to accept that European leaders (for

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the problem is that states do not make treaties, their leaders do) have been persistently motivated in their European policy over five decades by the same set of mental priorities and domestic constraints; once again, they are 'actors' rather than flesh-and-blood human beings with instincts, intuitions, traits and ideas that distinguish them one from the other. Insofar as economics and domestic lobbies do consistently loom large in the priorities of political leaders, one *can* make a story out of this, but it is, as Marxist historians used to say, 'no accident' that Moravcsik has run into trouble over De Gaulle, whose foreign policy is portrayed, somewhat counter-intuitively, as being chiefly dictated by concerns of the 'price of French wheat' and by agricultural concerns more generally (Moravcsik, 1998, p. 7).

Moravcsik's views on de Gaulle were restated and amplified in a lengthy two-part article in the *Journal of Cold War Studies*, where they were commented upon by a politely sceptical group of leading historians (Moravcsik, 2000a, b). Some restatement was certainly necessary. Three Dutch scholars have since convincingly argued that *The Choice for Europe* weights the evidence from both primary and secondary sources to make De Gaulle's motivations 'fit' the thesis its author was advancing (Lieshout *et al.*, 2004) while other scholars have advanced more general doubts about the empirical underpinning of Moravcsik's book. Parsons (2003, p. 29) is especially forthright: 'On my reading, the empirical evidence he offers is substantially incomplete at practically every step (and sometimes simply wrong)'.

Other historians have nibbled away at Moravcsik's approach by highlighting the centrality of geopolitical visions and ideals for political leaders at various moments in the integration process. Dyson and Featherstone, in their monumental study of the *Road to Maastricht*, certainly cannot be accused of neglecting the role of the Member States' economic motivations, but nevertheless demonstrate that the fact that almost all the statesmen involved in the Maastricht IGCs were 'Europeans of the heart' was decisive for the Treaty's success (Dyson and Featherstone, 1999, p. 749). Craig Parsons (2002) ably uses the case of debates in France between the Schuman Plan and the Treaty of Rome to show that the French decision to join the EEC was crucially determined by politicians with pro-Community beliefs who won the debate against equally plausible confederal and traditionalist realist beliefs advocated by other leaders whose personal prestige and political weight was arguably greater. There was nothing pre-ordained about France's signing the Treaty of Rome (TOR), in short: it required skilful leadership by men (especially Guy Mollet), who thought it was the right thing to do in the face of opposition from prominent politicians who thought otherwise. Helen Parr, in her recent study of Harold Wilson's foreign policy, explicitly rejects any suggestion that British policy was

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driven by rational calculations of economic needs and stresses the centrality of political and geopolitical motivations – although 'delusions of grandeur' might be a better phrase (Parr, 2006, pp. 189–90). The fear that Britain would become a 'greater Sweden' if it stayed out of the Community played a large role in official British thinking from 1963 onwards; as did the desire for Britain to take her 'rightful place' as the Community's mainspring once negotiations for entry had been successfully launched by the Heath government (Poggiolini, 2004).

One could multiply examples from the work of empirical historians, many of whom are unaware that they are even participating in this debate, but the point is clear. Moravcsik's 'analytical framework' is in essence *a narrative device*: a way of presenting the 'nature of the thing' with an aura of scientific detachment. But narratives written in this way are likely to run up against the hazard identified by G.R. Elton in his classic primer on historical methodology, *The Practice of History*: 'When the externally obtained scheme becomes doctrine, as too often it does, it stultifies the study of history by reducing history to a repository of examples selected or distorted to buttress the scheme' (Elton, 1967, p. 53). Moravcsik is certainly more nuanced than many of the crudely deterministic Marxists that Elton had in mind. But economic interest is but one instrument in the complex orchestra of the decision-making process and it is sensible not to allow that booming tuba to drown out subtler voices.

None of this should be taken to imply that there is anything wrong with making the broad *case* that European integration has been consistently shaped by the need to satisfy domestic economic constituencies, or indeed by the unintended spill-over effects of prior decisions. The core theses of both 'institutionalist' and 'structuralist' accounts are unquestionably plausible. It is merely that they both confuse part for whole. To this extent, they are arguably unwitting instances of what a very acute contemporary philosopher of history has called 'colligatory' historical interpretations: that is to say, 'partial interpretations of the past' that 'pick out patterns that are thought to be of particular interest, but are not normally intended to be comprehensive accounts of any particular subject' (McCullagh, 2004, p. 31). Such interpretations are commonplace in historiography and, insofar as they provoke debate and reassessment are useful scholarly tools, but they should not be confused with comprehensive interpretations. As the same philosopher has written: 'the aim of a comprehensive interpretation of a historical subject is to represent it fairly and credibly, not to find an account of the subject which makes the subject coherent. Coherence is not the aim. If the subject contains inconsistencies, then a fair account of it will reflect those inconsistencies' (McCullagh, 2004, p. 28).

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IV. Changing Perspectives

Comprehensive historical interpretations usually only take shape at some distance in time from the events themselves. Everybody has heard Zhou En Lai's quip that it was 'too early to tell' what the significance of the French Revolution was, but it is certainly true that it happens only rarely that major historical developments – and we can agree that the transferring and pooling of national sovereignty in institutions of collective European decision-making is a significant development – generate a broad interpretative consensus among historians in the short term. There are obvious reasons for this. Until we know (or at any rate have very good grounds indeed for guessing) how 'things turned out', it is not possible to construct a narrative that will command consensus. One sees this in the literature on the cold war: the 'Dean' of cold war studies, John Lewis Gaddis, ironically titled one of his books *We Now Know* and certainly the reception of his own recent narrative accounts of the cold war illustrates with some clarity that consensus on the subject is a long way off (Gaddis, 2006; Judt, 2006; Ribuffo, 2004).

It is certainly too early to know how European integration has turned out. Despite this fairly evident fact, academic debate over the EU, let alone political commentary, has been characterized by a headlong rush to judgement. Is the EU a 'harbinger' of future political-economic organization all over the world, as Moravcsik says? Is, as David Calleo suggests, Europe's 'hybrid confederacy' a 'highly creative evolution of the nation state' that will enable Europe to 'once more [. . .] give political lessons to others' (Calleo, 2001, p. 373; see also Padoa-Schioppa 2001, pp. 163–79, for the same basic argument)? Can we interpret European integration, as Stefano Bartolini implies, following Stein Rokkan, as the 'sixth crucial phase' in the development of the nation state in Europe that is also a challenge to the 'essence of political modernity', namely the idea that a particular territory must have 'a certain degree of cohesion' between its 'identity, social-economic practices and norms/institutions' (Bartolini, 2004, pp. 168 and 193)? Does the EU, as Jeremy Rifkin eloquently gushes, represent a 'European Dream' that 'beckons us' to 'a new age of inclusiveness, diversity, quality of life, deep play, sustainability, universal human rights, the rights of nature and peace on Earth' [*sic*] (Rifkin, 2004, p. 385)?

These rosy interpretations of the EU's historical significance may indeed come true. The process of European integration may indeed one day be held to be essentially the story of the birth of a cosmopolitan political unit that acts as an exemplar to the rest of the world (a belief that will structure and define future narratives). It is worth remarking, however, that most general historians of twentieth-century Europe, at any rate those writing in English, have been

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notably more cautious of the historical significance of the European project than EU specialists have been. Mark Mazower, in *The Dark Continent*, which is a highly sophisticated analysis of Europe's post-1918 parabola from ultra-nationalist ideology to somewhat smug consumerism and thus covers terrain where one would expect European integration to feature largely, dedicates no more than a handful of lines to European institutions, treating the EC-EU as a development in the wider process of modernization of European capitalism and certainly not as an agent of political transformation towards a Europe in which nation states count for less (Mazower, 1999, p. 409). Eric Hobsbawm, in *The Age of Extremes*, scarcely refers to European integration at all and mentions Jean Monnet only in the context of his role as the co-ordinator of the post-war French National Plan (Hobsbawm, 1994); Harold James, in *Europe Reborn*, his overview of twentieth-century Europe, concludes by arguing that 'the end of the twentieth century brought an unravelling of the threads that had constituted what older analysts had once believed to be a one-way process of modernization in the form of building a strong state', but suggests, too, that this fact is a generator of instability and political uncertainty, since the conviction that 'time ran unambiguously forwards' is no longer universal (James, 2003, pp. 443–4). Tony Judt, in *Postwar*, is much more extensive than any of these authors in his treatment of the EC-EU, but he is also a good deal more nuanced than is the wont of EU specialists: he sees, for instance, that enlargement has reopened the Eastern Question, a development that is likely to have unpredictable consequences (Judt, 2006, p. 768). P.M.H. Bell, in his characteristically fluent new history of *Twentieth-Century Europe*, interprets the process of European integration as essentially a sign of weakness; as the outcome of western European nations' lack of national self-confidence in the wake of the Second World War. He also adds that:

> It is hard to see how the different peoples within the EU can identify with a body whose own character remains uncertain. The institutions of what began as the EEC and became the EC and is now the EU, have always been in a state of transition, constantly on a journey to an unknown (or perhaps unstated) destination. British supporters of European integration have often made use of metaphors drawn from transport – catching or missing the European train was at one time a favourite figure of speech. But one wonders how many people actually want to live on a train moving at an uncertain speed towards an unnamed destination. In these circumstances the identity and ultimate character of the European Union remain in doubt and the gap between the advocates of closer unity and disgruntled or dubious public opinions seems to be growing wider. (Bell, 2006, p. 254)

At root, the greater circumspection of the general historians derives from their awareness of what the Sovietologist Leo Labedz once called 'the

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transitoriness of things in human history', a feeling for which Labedz regarded as 'the mark of true historical sensibility' (Labedz in Mount, 1992, p. 209). Ideologues see what they want to see; political scientists are professionally inclined to 'assume much more stability and thus predictability, than is warranted' (Blyth, 2006, p. 497). Historians know that sweeping changes can occur almost without warning and can reverse or overturn even seemingly consolidated political processes. In the 1920s, eminent intellectuals such as Harold Laski, Leonard Woolf and Norman Angell were every bit as sure as Rifkin, Calleo and Bartolini are today that a supranational organization – the League of Nations – was overcoming national sovereignty. Laski wrote in a book reprinted as late as 1937, for example, that the 'experience of the League gives us hope rather than despair' and that 'the idea of a world-state is slowly, painfully, hesitantly, taking shape before our eyes' (Laski, 1937, pp. 202–3). Such views were a commonplace among many leading democratic politicians of the day. Well, we now know what happened to the League and when historians write about it, they dwell primarily upon the structural and institutional weaknesses that rendered it incapable of standing up to the dictators, not the projects for economic development in the mandated territories and the statistical surveys that attracted the admiration of intellectuals before the rise of Hitler (Northedge, 1986).

More recently, one need only think of the way that most academic commentators – historians and international relations theorists alike – were dumbfounded by the speed and completeness with which Soviet communism collapsed (and also by the fact that one of the key causes of that collapse was the overnight transformation of a 'rigid structure', official Soviet ideology, into a source of 'extraordinary, albeit destabilizing dynamism') to appreciate that it is not implausible to hypothesize sudden and substantial reversals in trend (Kotkin, 2003, p. 30).

Naturally, these allusions to the League of Nations and to Communism should not be interpreted as a lurid prediction of the EU's impending doom. It is merely to state that history, like the weather, is apt to play tricks on those who think they have figured out the long-range forecast. It may be that 20 years from now, historians will be writing even more triumphant narratives about Europe's relentless progress towards ever closer union, but we should also face the fact that they may also be rewriting the previous 70 years to find the historical roots of the EU's decline into an ineffectual Commonwealth of states that had failed to find a solution to Europe's economic and cultural eclipse by India, China and the United States; may be writing off European integration as a 'civilized parenthesis' in the history of a continent that returned to xenophobic type as a result of public reaction to mass immigration from the third world; may be reconstructing the hubris that led it to construct

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an overambitious union whose culturally diverse constituent members, bound together in a rigid economic pact, proved no more able to stick together than the Member States of the Latin Monetary Union (Ferguson and Kotlikoff, 2000). None of these outcomes is *prima facie* impossible and the last one, as the performance of the Mediterranean states, especially Italy, at bringing about structural economic reforms lags, is already causing disquiet among academic experts (Blanke, 2006; Roubini, 2007).

Moreover, European integration is no more exempt than any other historical development from the process of revisionism – which means no more nor less than a shifting conviction of the 'nature of the thing'. One need not hypothesize disaster to see that the EU's story can be told in different ways. The novelty of John Gillingham's work lies here. The EU in Gillingham's view is actually obstructing, with what he regards as its attempts to create a federal super-state, the very forces that might push Europe towards unification in a functioning market economy. 'The SEA has set in motion an inexorable liberalization process that Brussels can delay or divert, but not stop', Gillingham intones solemnly (Gillingham, 2003, p. 406) For Gillingham, the EU:

> Requires far-reaching reform lest in the future it impede economic growth, breed social unrest and aggravate existing political problems [. . .] The EU should cease to pretend that the creation of a federal government for Europe is realistic politically, drop the attempt to engender Euro-patriotism [. . .] stop promoting ideas for the purpose of building bureaucracies, terminate the practice of governing by stealth and manipulation, eliminate inequitable and harmful income transfer programs like the CAP and most of the regional programs and return to first principles. (Gillingham, 2003, p. 447)

You can agree or disagree with this politically, but from the point of view of this article what is important is that the possession of such powerful neo-liberal views leads Gillingham to narrate the history of the EU in a radically different way from more conventional accounts (indeed, he stands them on their head). Gillingham gives dozens of pages to the absurdities of the CAP and corruption in the EU's regional policies, or to the limited impact of the EU's scientific research programmes; he gives much less to the musings of Europe's great and good about the EU's institutional future. His focus, in short, is on the shortcomings of what the EU *does*, rather than on the process of empowerment of the institutions through which the EU is governed, or the symbolism of what it stands for. This tendency is even more marked in his latest broadside, *Design for a New Europe*, where he explicitly argues that the recent history of the EU is one of bureaucratic creep and corruption, over-regulation, parochialism and over-ambition in foreign policy (Gillingham, 2006).

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Nor need new narratives of European integration necessarily share Gillingham's ostentatiously right-wing political opinions. A hard-hitting anti-liberalization history of the EU from the left, portraying the history of European integration as the story of how decision-making on contentious measures potentially damaging to the welfare and interests of the working class has been transferred to European level, is surely, given the current antipathy to neo-liberalism in France, Italy and other important countries, only a question of time. By the same token, a history of contemporary Europe that locates the significance of the EU within the wider process of the bureaucratization of modern life and the transformation of the liberal citizen into a passive recipient of distant technocratic rule seems equally plausible. Europe's 'democratic deficit' may easily come to be seen as 'the nature of the thing' and become the point of reference for future narratives.[3]

In other words, not only is politics a highly contingent affair, but what we currently think of as 'true story' of the EU is to a great degree politically contingent too. Narratives do not stay still and lie doggo. Nobody today would write a history of the British empire that portrayed British rule in India and Africa as a centuries-long civilizing mission and relegate the social and racial discrimination accorded to the 'natives' and the occasional massacres inflicted by British troops to a footnote. This is because we (or certainly enough of us to establish a consensus) no longer think of the British empire as a glorious episode in history and have, by now, a degree of detachment from the events and conduct of our imperial forebears. In the same way, we should acknowledge that the principal narrative accounts of European integration are impregnated with the belief that supranationalism is a desirable

[3] It is perhaps not for a historian to intervene in the debate over the 'democratic deficit'. However, it seems to me that even those political scientists who acknowledge that a problem exists, underestimate its severity. Andreas Follesdal and Simon Hix, for instance (Follesdal and Hix, 2006), insist in an acute article that the deficit can be filled by the application of greater transparency and more open competition for EU offices, notably the presidency of the Commission. Such reforms, they argue, had they been included in the 2004 Constitutional Treaty, would 'have captured the public's imagination' (p. 556).

Maybe, but they assume a great deal. Would Britons, Poles or Czechs really accept the election of a Belgian Federalist or a French anti-American to the Commission presidency after a high-profile contest? How would Scandinavians react to a member of Forza Italia being the victorious candidate for the PPE? It is not obvious that open results, openly arrived at, would guarantee consent and stability.

Follesdal and Hix further argue that the Constitutional Convention was a 'missed opportunity' since France and Britain blocked an alternative plan to allow the Parliament to choose the Commission President. But the EP is *part* of the democratic deficit problem. To begin with, as Follesdal and Hix say, it is elected through 'second order' elections (p. 552). But the problem is a wider one. You cannot identify with a body that is composed of people who speak in tongues you do not understand, whose histories you do not know and over whom you can exert no democratic accountability. The EP, with its distance from the electorate, is arguably more like the House of Lords than a national parliament (a comparison that is reinforced by the way that the party list system makes many MEPs nominees of their national party leaderships). But whereas the Lords has gradually lost powers, the EP has acquired huge responsibilities since Maastricht. Supranationallism is the principal cause of the democratic deficit, but that (if I may translate from the Italian) is a toad that many find hard to swallow.

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ideological goal and recount the history of European integration in terms of the progress Europe has made towards achieving this goal. If (and when) the focus of our beliefs changes, the facts we 'remember' about the past (i.e. accord significance to) will change too.[4]

It is perhaps also worth adding that political contingency works in both directions. Our understanding of what the EU is about may change with the political fortunes of the EU itself. But it is also true that academic concepts and narratives shape the perceptions of politicians and hence influence their actions. White has very plausibly shown how neofunctionalist ideas of the 'logic of integration' influenced Walter Hallstein and contributed to his mistaken strategy towards de Gaulle during the 'Empty Chair' crisis (White, 2003). By the same token, the seeming reluctance of Europe's leaders today to understand that there is popular discontent with the democratic deficit in Europe and that the EU is widely regarded as a big part of a wider problem of disenfranchisement and disempowerment, has surely been influenced by the boundless faith in the resilience of the European project that is a common theme in all the narratives I have been discussing. As Richard Whitman suggested in the course of a penetrating article on the French and Dutch referendum 'setbacks', 'history suggests, then, that the EU has a great capacity to move forward after a period of crisis' (Whitman, 2005, p. 679). How many times in the wake of the French and Dutch referendums was this sentiment publicly evoked by politicians and leading pundits? Probably thousands. But it is a lesson that can be evoked only if one subscribes to a certain historical memory of Europe's development and has embedded in one's mind the conviction that the EU has the future on its side. It is not Euroscepticism, but simply commonsense, to say that we cannot be so sure.

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[4] The choice of the word 'remember' intentionally echoes the language of Friedrich Kratochwil in his remarkable article 'History, Action and Identity: Revisiting the "Second" Great Debate and Assessing its Importance for Social Theory' (Kratochwil, 2006).

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